



△ Piece of fine, rich blue lapis lazuli rough

Lapis lazuli

For over 6,000 years, people have been drawn to the intense blue of lapis lazuli, often flecked with golden glints like stars in the night sky. It is relatively rare, and commonly forms in crystalline limestones as a product of heat and pressure; the strong blue colour is mostly caused by the mineral lazurite, although lapis also contains pyrite and calcite, and usually some sodalite and haüyne. The highest-quality material is a deep, dark blue, with minor patches of white calcite and brassy yellow pyrite. A large quantity of modern lapis material originates from mines in Afghanistan, its original source (see below), while lighter blue material is found in Chile, and lesser amounts in Italy, Argentina, Russia, and the USA.

Lapis lazuli in history

For many centuries, the only known deposits of lapis lazuli were those at Sar-e-Sang, in a remote mountain valley in Afghanistan, from where it was widely traded across the ancient world. Objects from ancient Egypt containing lapis lazuli date from at least 3100 BCE and include scarabs, pendants, inlays in gold and silver, and beads. Powdered lapis lazuli was used as a cosmetic – the first eye shadow (along with malachite) – as a blue pigment, and as a medicine. Outside ancient Egypt, the tomb of Sumerian Queen Pu-abi (2500 BCE) contained numerous gold and silver jewellery pieces richly adorned with lapis, and the Chinese and the Greeks were carving lapis lazuli as early as the 4th century BCE.

Key pieces



Ancient Egyptian gold pectoral | Featuring a central scarab carved from lapis lazuli supporting a gold disc that represents the sun, this pectoral was created for the pharaoh Amenemopet of the 21st Dynasty, and found in Tanis.



17th-century ewer | Created in the Miseroni workshop in Florence, Italy, around 1608, this ewer was carved from two separate pieces of lapis lazuli. The foot, collar, and handle are made from gold, the handle in the form of a cherub.

Specification

Chemical name Sodium, calcium, aluminosilicate (Lazurite)
Formula $\text{Na}_3\text{Ca}(\text{Al}_3\text{Si}_3\text{O}_{12})\text{S}$ | **Colours** Blue | **Structure** Cubic | **Hardness** 5–5.5 | **SG** 2.4 | **RI** 1.5 | **Lustre** Dull to vitreous | **Streak** Blue



Locations

1 USA 2 Chile 3 Argentina 4 Italy 5 Afghanistan 6 Russia



Cartier Nouvelle Vague ring | Created by Cartier, Paris, this 18-karat yellow gold ring is set with nine lapis lazuli cabochons and nine chrysoprase cabochons, along with 112 brilliant-cut diamonds.